Speaking and Writing Self-Grading Rubrics

Updated for the 2026 Format

Introduction

The hardest part of preparing for the speaking and writing section of the TOEFL is analyzing your own responses. We at TST Prep strongly suggest that you get your speaking and writing evaluated by a professional TOEFL teacher, but do understand that some students would rather not seek out the advice of an expert. This document is designed to help students who have no choice but to study on their own.

Again, let me reiterate that this is not the best way to maximize your score. When you have a toothache, you visit the dentist, and you don't try to pull out your own tooth. There are specific skills that the TOEFL graders are looking for, so please consider hiring a professional teacher to provide you with some feedback.

The Speaking Section

As of January 21st, 2026, the TOEFL Speaking section consists of two tasks: *Listen and Repeat* and *Take an Interview*. For *Listen and Repeat*, you are required to listen to a statement of about 20 words or fewer and repeat exactly what you heard. You will encounter 7 statements to repeat on test day.

This is immediately followed by a task called *Take an Interview*. You will be interviewed and asked four questions about an unknown topic. The most common topics deal with habits, school, education, and the workplace.

Listen and Repeat

The first task in the TOEFL Speaking is *Listen and Repeat*. One of the best ways to improve your score is to understand the grading criteria. According to ETS's TOEFL Technical Manual, these are the scoring dimensions:

Fluency

- Speaking rate (Do you speak fast enough?)
- Length of uninterrupted "runs" (Do you bring words together?)
- Number of pauses
- Number of hesitations

Intelligibility

- Correctness of pronunciation
- Naturalness of speech rhythm (Do you have natural speech music?)
- Naturalness of prosody (e.g., syllable stress)

Repeat Accuracy

- Correctly repeated words
- Similarity to prompt

Below is a checklist of seven questions. Use it to assess your performance and identify areas in need of improvement.

Listen and Repeat Checklist	
Question	**Notes**
Did I add or miss any words? (repeat accuracy)	
Did I utter the correct form of every word, for example, “belonged” should be “belongs”? (repeat accuracy)	
Did I avoid vocal fillers like ‘uh’ or ‘um’? (fluency)	
Did I hesitate or repeat words? (fluency)	
Did I repeat the sentence in 10 seconds or less? (fluency)	
Did I bring words together and speak smoothly? (intelligibility)	
Did I clearly and correctly pronounce all the words? (intelligibility)	
What can I do better next time?	

*Note that there are no numerical score values. The point of this exercise is not for you to assess yourself with a TOEFL-like score, but instead, to identify strengths and weaknesses so you have a better idea of what you need to improve.

Take an Interview

The second task in the TOEFL Speaking is *Take an Interview*. One of the best ways to improve your score is to understand the grading criteria. According to ETS's TOEFL Technical Manual, these are the scoring dimensions:

Fluency

- Speaking rate - Do you speak fast enough?
- Length of uninterrupted "runs" (Do you bring words together?)
- Number of pauses
- Number of hesitations

Intelligibility

- Correctness of pronunciation
- Naturalness of speech rhythm (Do you have natural speech music?)
- Naturalness of prosody (e.g., syllable stress)

Language Use: Vocabulary and Grammar

- Vocabulary diversity (Do you use a lot of different words?)
- Vocabulary richness (Do you use a few difficult words or phrases?)
- Grammaticality (Do you use a range of grammatical structures?)
- Grammatical accuracy

Organization

- Discourse coherence (Do you have a clear beginning, middle, and end?
- Use of discourse connectives (e.g., for example)

Take an Interview Checklist	
Question	**Notes**
Did I include fewer than three fillers (*uh, um, you know*)?	
Did I stay on topic and answer the question?	
Did I avoid hesitating or repeating more than two times?	
Did I speak for at least 42 seconds?	
Did I use at least two transitional words or phrases?	
Did I elaborate on the topic with a well-developed personal example, anecdote, or explanation?	
Did I provide a response at least 110 words long?	
Did I include at least one strong phrase, idiom, or expression?	
Did I speak at a natural pace, not too fast or slow?	
Did I speak clearly enough to be easily understood? (check with speech-to-text software)	
What can I do better next time?	

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The Writing Section

As of January 21st, 2026, the TOEFL Writing section consists of three writing tasks: *Build a Sentence*, Write an Email, and Write for an Academic Discussion. The first task type, Build a Sentence, is an exercise designed to measure your grammar. You do not need a grading rubric for that task.

Write an Email and Write for an Academic Discussion require writing for an extended length of time. They are productive exercises where you will be expected to exhibit your writing skills.

According to ETS' TOEFL Technical Manual, the grading criteria for each task is similar. The main difference is that Write for an Email will measure whether or not you can correctly employ polite language. This is not required in Write for an Academic Discussion.

TOEFL Writing Grading Criteria		
Grading Criteria	**Scoring Dimensions**	**What Needs Improvement**
Content	Number of Sentences	*Your response includes too many short sentences.*
	Discourse Coherence	*Your response does not include transitional words and phrases.*
	Similarity to Prompt	*Your response does not address all three bullet points.*
Vocabulary and Grammar	Sentence Variety	*Your response includes too many simple sentences.*
	Word Frequency	*Your response does not include much varied vocabulary.*
	Correctness of Collocations	*Your response omits phrases or uses them awkwardly.*
Social Conventions *email only	Politeness Indicators	*Your response does not include or incorrectly uses modals and hedge words.*
Accuracy	Grammaticality	*Your response includes awkward or inappropriate grammar.*
	Grammatical Errors	*Your response contains too many incorrect grammatical structures.*
	Word or Usage Errors	*Your response includes words and phrases that do not fit the context.*
	Mechanical Errors	*Your response has too many typos, misspellings, or formatting errors.*

Even though ETS's grading criteria are informative, it may still be challenging for test-takers to use them in a meaningful way. The Write an Email and Academic Discussion checklists have been designed for independent test-takers who want to understand their weaknesses and improve their score.

Write an Email Checklist	
Question	**Notes**
Did I write at least 100 words?	
Did my response include 11 sentences or fewer?	
Did I use at least one transitional word or phrase?	
Did I address all three bullet points?	
Did I have at least two sentences with more than one clause?	
Did I include one sentence with a coordinating conjunction and one sentence with a subordinating conjunction?	
Did I include at least two words or phrases that show an advanced level of vocabulary?	
Did I include a polite opening and closing statement?	
Did I include the word could or would or a hedge word at least once?	
Did I have fewer than four typos, spelling errors, or formatting mistakes?	
After using a grammar checker, did I have fewer than two grammatical mistakes?	
What can I do better next time?	

Write for an Academic Discussion	
Question	**Notes**
Did I write at least 120 words?	
Did my response include 12 sentences or fewer?	
Did I use at least one transitional word or phrase?	
Did I address the prompt and stay on topic?	
Did I add to the discussion with a relevant opinion, a supporting reason, and an appropriate example?	
Did I have at least two sentences with more than one clause?	
Did I include one sentence with a coordinating conjunction and one sentence with a subordinating conjunction?	
Did I include at least two words or phrases that show an advanced level of vocabulary?	
Did I have fewer than four typos, spelling errors or formatting mistakes?	
After using a grammar checker, did I have fewer than two grammatical mistakes?	
What can I do better next time?	

*Note that there are no numerical score values. The point of this exercise is not for you to assess yourself with a TOEFL-like score, but instead, to identify strengths and weaknesses so you have a better idea of what you need to improve.

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If you ever feel like you need more control over your studies, guided by the advice of a professional TOEFL teacher, you will find our services on our website TST Prep.

Get in touch at contact@tstprep.com